

The Wright brothers

The fathers of powered FLIGHT



Wilbur Wright



Orville Wright

Young tinkers

Wilbur Wright was born in 1867 in Indiana, USA, and his brother, Orville, was born four years later. From an early age the boys were **obsessed** with all things **MECHANICAL** and with the idea of flight. By 1895, they started building their own bicycles, but it wasn't long before they started to dream about building their own **flying machines**.

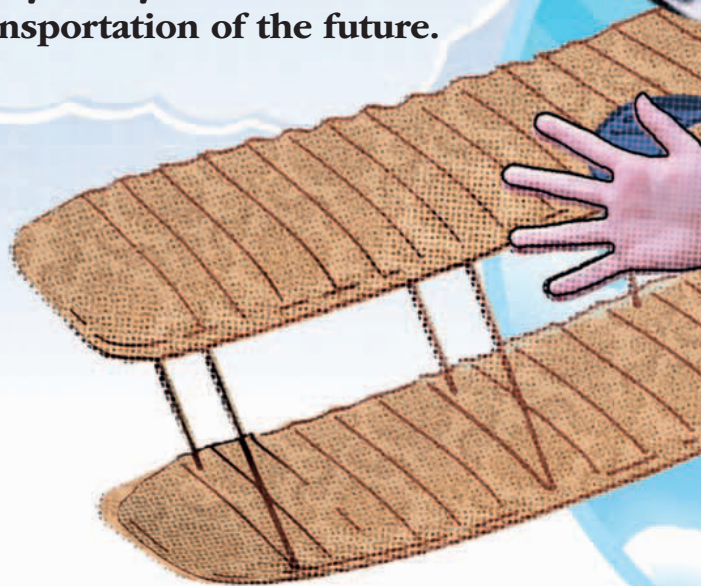
They couldn't have done it without...

Wilbur was inspired to build an **AIRCRAFT** when he read about German glider pilot **OTTO LILIENTHAL** (1848–1896), an early pioneer of aviation.



By the way... we tossed a coin to see who would fly first. Wilbur won, but the engine stalled, so it was Orville's attempt that made it into the history books.

These pioneers made the first ever sustained, powered flight. Before them, flight was a useless novelty—they turned it into the transportation of the future.



Things look up

Wilbur wrote to the Smithsonian Institute—a famous museum in Washington, DC—and asked for all the information they had on aeronautics (the science of flight). The brothers studied **BIRDS** and used what they had learned to build their own **gliders**. They built a wind tunnel to test all their designs, but soon realized that, if their flying machine were to travel any distance, it would need something to **propel** it.

